

THE TRANSMITTER

Transit Fiction
The Signal Cycle · Third Trilogy · Book VIII



Rudolfo Valentino

BOOK EIGHT

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

*While he transmitted the signal, she could remain the receiver.
When he falls silent — the receiver is forced to become the transmitter.*

2888.

Four registers of the text: Main narrative — the voice of the telling. [Square brackets] — Arthur's inner voice. Rare, like an echo. { Curly braces } — Melissa's notes and voice. Kindling. // Monospace block // — the Grid. His — in the archive. Hers — rising.

PART I. THE ARCHIVE

Chapter 1. Forty-Three Notebooks

She began with the first.

Not because she didn't know where to begin. Because it was the only way — from the very start, in chronological order, the way biologists do with field journals when they're hunting an anomaly. Take the whole body of data. Pass through it. Find the point where something went wrong.

The third of September. Seven years ago.

{ A man in the library, the place by the second window. Came at 9:14 — exactly, as if by a schedule that doesn't exist. Reads pages 44–67, the third time in a row. He doesn't reread — he repeats. The difference: repetition is a ritual, rereading is curiosity. He has a ritual. What is he ritualizing? I don't know yet. Delay before answering the librarian — 2.3 seconds. Not hesitation. It's — a layer between the incoming and the outgoing. He translates. Who translates? }

Melissa set the notebook aside. Stood, poured water, came back.

Who translates. She'd written that seven years ago — and given no answer. Because there was no answer then. Because she hadn't yet been able to phrase the question more precisely.

Now she could.

Not who. What. What in him translated — and from where.

{ Fourth day of observation. He always chooses a place in a café with his back to the wall, facing the entrance. Not out of caution — out of a need to see the whole room at once. As if he needs a full view, otherwise — discomfort. An animal habit? Or something else. Writing it down. }

She leafed slowly. Outside was summer — real, stifling, with open windows and the smell of heated asphalt. Forty-three notebooks. She'd set aside the whole Sunday for it.

The second year. The third.

{ Today he stopped in front of a florist's window. Stood for three minutes. Looked not at the flowers — at the reflection of the street in the glass. I stood twenty paces off. He saw in the reflection what I saw directly — but from a different angle. A different cross-section of the same space. It seemed to me that he prefers exactly this. The reflection, not the direct look. Why? }

The fourth year. The fifth.

{ He was at the harbor today. Stood at the pier and looked at the water. Before, he looked differently. Today — like everyone. I can't explain the difference, but it was there. Something went out of the way his gaze touches the world. I don't know what it means. But it's important. }

She stopped at this entry.

The harbor. Autumn. A year ago — less than a year. She reread it. Then again.

"Something went out of the way his gaze touches the world."

She hadn't known then what exactly had gone. Now she knew: the Grid. The second sight. The organ that made his gaze different. She'd seen the result — before she understood the cause.

It was the first clue.

CLUE 01 DATE: AUTUMN · HARBOR OBSERVATION: THE GAZE CHANGED INTERPRETATION: THE ORGAN IS FADING STATUS: CONFIRMED RETROSPECTIVELY

Melissa looked at the block. Monospace type, a left margin — she'd unconsciously copied his manner. Seven years watching how he wrote. She'd absorbed the form before she understood she was absorbing it.

She didn't erase it. She left it.

If the form is his — then it works. Then it's precise.

Chapter 2. The Detective's Mainspring

Every investigation has a question. Her investigation's question was this: when exactly?

Not what happened — that she knew. Not why — that was clear too. When. The exact date when he crossed the line beyond which there was no return. When the organ began to atrophy irreversibly.

It was important. Not for him — he could no longer be changed. For her. For understanding the mechanism. For seeing, and not only feeling.

She took a clean sheet and wrote out the dates of the anomalies — the entries where something was wrong.

TIMELINE · RECONSTRUCTION ————— SPRING -7 · NORMAL ·
ALL REGISTERS ACTIVE SUMMER -7 · NORMAL · GLANCE AT ALEX — FIRST ENVY AUTUMN -7 ·
ANOMALY 01 · HARBOR · THE GAZE CHANGED WINTER -7 · ANOMALY 02 · LIBRARY · SLIDES,
DOESN'T READ SPRING -6 · ANOMALY 03 · DINNER · SHADOW OF THE OLD — A FRACTION OF A
SECOND SPRING -6 · LOWEST POINT · HE ASKS ABOUT THE CITY — EMPTY ANSWER
————— QUESTION: WHERE BETWEEN SUMMER -7 AND AUTUMN -7
DID THE POINT OF NO RETURN PASS?

She looked at the timeline. Summer minus seven. The anomaly — autumn minus seven. Between them — two, at most three months.

She opened the notebook from that period.

{ August. He came to the café later than usual. Sat at the third table — not his own. The place by the window was taken. He didn't wait, didn't move — just sat where there was room, without visible discomfort. This is new. Before, he waited for his place. Writing it down as a deviation. }

August. The place.

Melissa turned the page.

{ August, a few days later. A conversation with the neighbor in the stairwell. I observed from the stairs. He answered without a pause. For the first time in three years — not a second of translation. Simply answered. She was surprised — I saw it in her face. He smiled. It looked like a success. For him, probably, it was a success. I wrote it down and didn't know what to think. }

There it was.

August. The first answer without the pause of translation. The first time — directly, without a layer between himself and the world. He thought it was a victory. It was the point of no return.

Not autumn. Not the harbor. August. The stairwell. The neighbor with the question about the elevator.

POINT OF NO RETURN · ESTABLISHED DATE: AUGUST PLACE: STAIRWELL EVENT: FIRST ANSWER
WITHOUT THE PAUSE OF TRANSLATION SUBJECT TOOK IT FOR: A VICTORY IN FACT: THE
BEGINNING OF THE ORGAN'S ATROPHY NOTE: HE DIDN'T KNOW. I DIDN'T KNOW. NO ONE KNEW.

Melissa closed the notebook. Then opened it again — and wrote beneath the Grid, by hand:

{ Translation without loss is impossible. He knew that. He tried to get around it. The price turned out to be — himself. }

She sat a long time. Outside it was growing dark.

The investigation didn't make it easier for her. It made it more precise. That wasn't the same thing — but it was something.

Chapter 3. The Archive Against the Living Man

The next day she went to him.

Not because she wanted to. Because she needed to check the archive against the original. A biologist can't work only with records — you have to return to the object. Even if the object has changed. Especially if.

He opened the door quickly. Smiled. Invited her in.

"Melissa. Good that you came. I was just reading."

She came in. Looked around.

The apartment was tidy, quiet, bright. On the table — a book face down, a chocolate wrapper serving as a bookmark. In the kitchen — clean plates on the rack. Everything in its place. Everything — correct.

{ Clean. Calm. Not a single object that isn't where it belongs. Before, there was always something shifted with him — a chair turned slightly, a book not on the shelf but on the windowsill. As if the space around him lived differently. Now — no. Now — like everyone. }

"Tea?" he asked.

"Yes, thank you."

He went to the kitchen. She stayed standing by the door and looked at his back.

Shoulders squared. An even step. No tension — that particular tension of presence in someone else's space, which for seven years she'd known how to read at a glance. He moved like a man at home. Because now — he was.

{ This is exactly what he wanted. I look at the result and understand: he got exactly what he was after. Calm. Belonging. The right not to translate every step. This shouldn't be a tragedy. I'm trying to convince myself it isn't a tragedy. }

He came back with two cups.

"How are things?"

"Working," she said. "Going through old notes."

"I see." He nodded. "Finding anything interesting?"

"Not sure yet."

They sat. He told her something about a book he was reading — about the structure, about how the author builds time. He spoke well, coherently, with pleasure. She listened and thought: he's become a better speaker. Freer. Without that pause, without the layer between thought and word.

That was a loss too. The pause of translation was his — personal, recognizable, like handwriting. Now — someone else's speech. Correct, but someone else's.

{ I sit across from a man I've known seven years. I can list: the color of his eyes, the habit of holding a cup with two hands, the way he looks a little to the left of his interlocutor when he thinks. I know him. And I don't recognize him. It's like looking

at a photograph of a person and thinking — I know this face — while he stands beside you, alive, and it isn't him. Or — it's him. But a different him. Or — what's left of him after the main thing left. }

"You look well," she said. Again. That phrase had become her ritual — empty and precise at once.

"Summer," he said. "A good summer this year."

She finished the tea. Said goodbye.

Outside she stopped, closed her eyes for a second.

{ The archive is more precise than the original. That's frightening. The archive — is the one I knew. The original — is the one who is. Between them — the point of no return. August. The stairwell. The neighbor with the question about the elevator. }

She opened her eyes and walked home.

PART II. THE KINDLING

Chapter 4. The First Grid

It happened at the market.

Not in her study, not at the desk with the notebooks — at the market, on a Wednesday, between the rows of greens and the rows of fish. She was going for parsley and suddenly stopped.

Before her was a man — about fifty, in a gray jacket, looking at a stall of apples. A long time. Too long for choosing apples.

Melissa looked at him and felt something she didn't at once find a name for. Not curiosity — more precise. Not interest — sharper. Something that began several layers before words.

The man took an apple. Turned it over. Put it back. Walked off without buying.

She stood and thought: he didn't come for apples. He came to be among people. He's lonely, and he chooses places where people gather — the market, the café, the library. Not for contact. For the density of presence. So as not to be alone in space.

How did she know this?

Seven years of observation. Seven years — learning to read one person. And now: the organ worked on its own, without an object, on a stranger.

MARKET · WEDNESDAY · 11:23 OBJECT: STRANGER · M · 50±5 PATTERN: CHOICE WITHOUT PURCHASE INTERPRETATION: PRESENCE AS THE GOAL LONELINESS · TACTIC: DENSITY CONFIDENCE: 80%

She looked at what she'd written. Then glanced around — as if someone might have seen.

The Grid. Her Grid.

Imprecise, awkward, not at all like his — his was instant, like a breath, without effort. Hers — with effort, with a pause, with the question "am I seeing this right." But — it. The same instrument, different hands.

She bought the parsley and walked home faster than usual.

In the evening she opened the notebook.

{ For seven years I watched him do it. I thought I was only observing. It turns out — I was learning. The body absorbed it before the head understood. This isn't mine. It's his — inherited. Or borrowed. I don't yet know the difference. }

She wrote this and stopped over the last phrase.

Inherited or borrowed. That was a question that would take time.

Chapter 5. What Grows

The Grid grew slowly — like any organ that develops not from birth, but in maturity.

At first she noticed it only in moments of rest — in a queue, on public transit, when the mind isn't occupied with anything specific. Then she began to notice it at work: she'd look at a colleague and understand something that wasn't said aloud. Then — in the street, on strangers, in cafés.

It wasn't reading minds. It was reading structure. The architecture beneath the surface — his words. Now her experience.

CAFÉ · THURSDAY · 14:07 OBJECT: TWO · F+M · 30-35 PATTERN: CONVERSATION WITHOUT CONTACT — LOOKING IN DIFFERENT DIRECTIONS — SYNCHRONOUS GESTURE: BOTH TOOK A CUP — PAUSE 4 SEC BEFORE EACH ANSWER INTERPRETATION: TIRED OF EACH OTHER THE FORM HOLDS · THE CONTENT HAS GONE CONFIDENCE: 70%

She looked at the block. Seventy percent — she wasn't sure yet. His confidence was always higher. He saw more precisely, faster, deeper.

She saw differently.

It was an important distinction. Not worse, not better — different. He saw the architecture of space, movement, vectors. She saw relationships, exhaustion, the distance between people. He — the physics. She — the chemistry.

{ I'm curious: if we both looked at the same scene — what would each of us see? His Grid and my Grid would give different reports on one reality. It doesn't mean one of us is wrong. It means reality is larger than one angle of view. }

She wrote this and thought: he never asked that question. He didn't know about her observations — and so couldn't compare. She knew about his — and could.

That too was inherited. The habit of seeing with double vision — her own and his.

Chapter 6. Nora

Nora called on Friday.

"Melissa, are you coming on Saturday? I'm inviting everyone — Alex, Daniel, Arthur. We haven't gathered in a while."

A pause.

"Yes," said Melissa. "I'll come."

She hung up and sat still for several minutes. Then opened the notebook.

{ Dinner at Nora's. All the same — Alex, Daniel, Arthur. I'll observe everyone at once for the first time in a long while. Not only him — everyone. That's a different scale. It's interesting and frightening at once. Frightening — because I know what I'll see. He'll be part of the company. One of them. Content. And no one at that table will know what it cost him, the thing it cost. }

On Saturday she came at eight.

Nora hugged her at the door — tightly, for real.

"Good that you're here. Arthur's already here, Alex is late as always."

Melissa entered the living room.

Arthur sat by the window with a glass of wine — relaxed, bright, drawn into a conversation with Daniel about some film. He raised his head, saw her, nodded.

"Melissa. Glad to see you."

"So am I."

DINNER · SATURDAY · 20:14 PRESENT: NORA · ALEX · DANIEL · ARTHUR · I ARTHUR:
POSITION BY THE WINDOW · BACK TO THE WALL — NO ARTHUR: BACK TO THE ROOM · DOESN'T
SEE THE ENTRANCE BEFORE: NEVER NOW: NORMAL FOR HIM

She took a glass. Alex arrived, brought wine, filled the room with himself — as Alex always did. Nora set the table. Daniel told a story about a business trip.

Melissa watched Arthur.

He laughed at Daniel's story — in the right places, sincerely. Passed the bread when asked. Listened. Spoke. Took part.

Everything correct. Everything in place.

{ I look at him and see a man who knows how to be in company. It isn't pretense — it's real. He truly is here, truly glad, truly taking part. But I remember another one. The one who also took part — and at the same time saw beneath the surface. Simultaneously. Not instead — together. He could be here and see the architecture of this "here." Now it's one without the other. Only here. Only the surface. }

After dinner Nora brought out better wine. The conversation grew slower, warmer.

"Arthur, you've changed," Alex said suddenly. Not accusingly — a statement. "In a good way. You're... more here."

Arthur smiled.

"I'm trying."

"It's working," said Daniel.

Nora raised her glass.

"To that."

Everyone raised theirs. Melissa too. She drank and looked at him over the rim of the glass.

{ They drink to him. And they're right to. He's become better at the thing they know how to measure. I have nothing to object with. Except that I know — and can't explain it in a way that wouldn't sound like a reproach of his happiness. }

They parted late. Melissa walked home.

The summer city, half past eleven, quiet streets. She thought about Alex — "more here." True. And she thought: what does it mean to be here without the ability to see beneath the surface. It's a different "here." Smaller in volume. But, perhaps, whole in its own way.

She didn't know. It was a question without an answer.

Yet.

Chapter 7. Oma

There was one gap in the archive.

Seven years of notes — and almost nothing about the harbor. One entry: "He was at the harbor today. I saw from far off." And that's all. She'd been too far away. She hadn't gone closer — she kept the observer's distance.

Now she went to the harbor herself.

Not because she expected anything. Simply — it was his place. The place where the Grid faded. The place where something ended. She wanted to stand there and see what she would see.

The harbor at the end of July was different than in autumn. Summery — with tourists, with the smell of ice cream over the diesel, with children at the railings. Arthur had been here in autumn — alone, in the cold, in a last attempt.

She stood at that pier — she knew roughly where. The second from the entrance, by the cargo ferry.

She looked at the water.

HARBOR · PIER 2 · 10:31 WATER: DARK · CALM FERRY: STANDING · DEPARTING VOYAGE AT 12:00 PEOPLE BY THE WATER: 7 ARCHITECTURE BENEATH THE SURFACE: — MAN ON THE LEFT · SEEING SOMEONE OFF · LONG AGO — WOMAN WITH A CHILD · FIRST TIME HERE — TEENAGER AT THE RAILING · WAITING · DOESN'T KNOW FOR WHAT CONFIDENCE: 65%

She looked at her block.

Sixty-five percent. His here was a hundred. In this place, in the best days — a hundred percent, instant, precise. She saw the same — slower, softer, with a margin of error.

But she saw.

"Do you come here often?"

She turned. Beside her stood a woman — about sixty, in a light coat, a bag over her shoulder.

"No," said Melissa. "First time."

"And I come every Thursday," said the woman. "For thirty years now. The ferry leaves at twelve, always the same. There's something in it. Constancy."

The woman smiled and walked on.

Melissa watched her go.

{ Oma. Not her Oma — a different woman, a different story. But a similar type. The kind who comes to the water not for the water — for constancy within movement. The ferry leaves — and returns. It's a rhythm that holds. He came here too. Not for constancy — for clarity. Here the Grid worked sharpest of all. Here he saw most precisely. And here — he stopped seeing. The place of power became the place of the organ's death. That isn't accidental. }

The ferry sounded its horn. Twelve minus fifteen.

She stood a little longer. Then turned and walked home.

The harbor gave her not an answer — one more question. Why here, exactly? Why did the organ choose this place for its last flash?

Perhaps — because here he was most himself. And here, too — he gave himself permission to stop.

PART III. THE BOUNDARY

Chapter 8. Resurrection from the Notes

She began to write about him.

Not observation notes — something else. Not date, time, pattern. Simply — him. As she knew him.

It was more frightening than she'd expected.

{ He entered the library and knew at once where everyone was sitting. Not because he looked — because he read it. The density of presence, the direction of attention, tension or ease — all of it came to him before he took a step. I watched his gaze hundreds of times. He didn't scan — he received. }

She stopped. Reread.

It was precise. But it was her description. Her words about his perception. Not him — her version of him.

She wrote on.

{ When he was silent — it wasn't emptiness. It was a filled silence. He was silent and at the same time doing something the whole time — inside, behind the layer of quiet. You could see it in the hands: they weren't motionless. The fingers moved a little. As if he were turning over something invisible. Data? Observations? I don't know. I never asked. }

She set down the pen.

"I never asked."

Seven years — and she'd never asked him directly. It was her principle: the observer doesn't interfere with the object. She'd guarded the purity of the observation so carefully that she'd denied herself the chance to simply talk to him.

That was a loss of another kind.

{ I reconstruct him from what I saw from outside. I don't have his inner voice. I don't have his Grid. I have only what seeped through the surface — gestures, pauses, glances, the way he held a cup. It's a great deal. And it's — not him. It's my cast of him. My archive. My Arthur, who lives only here, in these notebooks. }

She wrote this and looked at it a long time.

My Arthur.

That was the boundary. The one she was supposed to see.

Chapter 9. Where the Boundary Is

She called Nora.

"Can I come by? I need to talk."

"Of course. I'm home."

They sat in Nora's kitchen with coffee. Outside it was raining — rain again, August had brought many rains.

"I want to ask you something," said Melissa. "About Arthur."

Nora nodded.

"You've known him a long time."

"Seven years. As long as you."

"Did you ever notice — before — anything unusual? In the way he looked at things?"

Nora was silent. Thought.

"He saw differently," she said at last. "I don't know how to explain it. As if he knew something about you that you didn't know yourself. Not eerie — just... precise. Sometimes he'd say something, and you'd think: how did he notice that." A pause. "Now it isn't so."

"Do you miss it?"

Nora was surprised.

"Miss it?" She thought. "No. He's... better now. Easier to be with. Before, there was a sense that near him you had to be a little collected. As if he saw right through you. It isn't bad — but it's an effort. Now it's just good. Just pleasant."

{ Nora misses the ease, not the depth. That's honest. That's most people — they want it to be nice to be near, not to be read. That's normal. It isn't bad. It's simply different from what I wanted. }

"And you?" asked Nora. "How is it for you with him now?"

Melissa thought.

"It's good with him," she said. "It's just... I worked with that Arthur. The one who was there before."

"Worked?"

"Observed. Kept notes." A pause. "For a long time."

Nora looked at her.

"And?"

"And now I don't know where the boundary is. Between what I know about him — and what I invented about him. Between observation and... appropriation."

Nora was silent. Then said slowly:

"Melissa. You love him."

A long pause.

"I know him," said Melissa.

"Sometimes that's the same thing."

{ Nora said it simply, without pressure. As a fact. I don't know whether it's true. I know that for seven years I looked at him the way one looks at something important. Maybe that is love — in one of its kinds. Not the kind it's customary to call love. Another. Quieter. More precise. Or — just different. }

She left Nora's without an answer. The rain didn't stop.

Chapter 10. Memory and Appropriation

That night she didn't sleep.

She lay and thought about the boundary. About where "I know a person" ends and "I created a person out of the way I knew them" begins.

Forty-three notebooks. Seven years. Thousands of observations, entries, interpretations. All of it — her. Her gaze. Her language. Her categories.

He'd never read it. He didn't know how she saw him. It was her Arthur — existing only in the notebooks, only in her head.

And now — only there.

{ There are two Arthurs. One — alive, drinks tea, reads books, laughs at Daniel's stories. The other — in the archive, in forty-three notebooks, in my memory. One — became someone else. The other — stayed himself. I can resurrect the second. But it will be my resurrection, not his. I'll speak in his words — the ones I wrote down. I'll think his thoughts — the ones I reconstructed. Is that honest? Is it appropriation? Or is it — the only thing one can do with loss? }

She got up at three in the morning. Went to the desk.

Opened the notebook.

And began to write — not about him. About what she would do with what she'd inherited from him.

{ The Grid isn't his. Now — mine. The ability to see the architecture beneath the surface isn't his gift left to me as an inheritance. It's what grew in me over seven years of observation. I don't know if it would exist without him — probably not. But it's mine. I'm responsible for how I use it. }

She wrote this and felt something like relief.

Not joy. Not reconciliation. Simply — clarity.

She isn't resurrecting him. She's continuing what he began. Those are different things.

Different — and it's important not to confuse them.

PART IV. THE TRANSMITTER

Chapter 11. The First Transmission

At the beginning of September she understood it was time.

She didn't decide — she understood. The body knew before the head: evening, desk, notebook, and something else that used to be his — and now waited for her.

She sat at the desk. Before her — a clean notebook. Not the archive, not the observation. A new one.

She opened it to the first page.

Put the time. Not the date — the time.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: ? RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPENING

She looked at it. Then wrote beneath the block, by hand, small:

{ I don't know to whom I'm transmitting. He didn't know — and transmitted for seven years. So it isn't a required condition. }

She began to write.

Not about him. Not observations. Simply — what she'd seen today. A man on the metro who read a book and from time to time closed it and looked out the window — not out the window, through it. The architecture of his loneliness. The density of his silence.

She wrote slowly. Not like him — his was fast, precise, confident. Hers — with stops, with crossings-out, with a search for the word.

But something was there. Something real.

METRO · 18:43 OBJECT: M · 40±5 · BOOK IN HAND PATTERN: READING — PAUSE — GAZE THROUGH THE GLASS CYCLE: 7-8 MIN INTERPRETATION: THE BOOK AS SHELTER · THE WINDOW AS EXIT HE ALTERNATES · CAN'T CHOOSE CONFIDENCE: 75%

She closed the notebook.

TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:44 SIGNAL: WEAK · RISING RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN

She went to bed.

She didn't know whether there was a recipient. It didn't matter.

What mattered — the channel was open.

Chapter 12. Sati

In October she met Sati.

By chance — in the queue at the pharmacy. Melissa recognized her by her bearing: a straight back, the head a little to the side, the gaze — attentive, not aggressive. Arthur had mentioned her once. The only one who saw his "not from here" at first sight.

Melissa stood behind her in the queue and thought: ask or not.

She asked.

"Are you Sati?"

The woman turned. Without surprise — as if strangers addressed her regularly.

"Yes."

"I'm Melissa. We have a mutual acquaintance — Arthur."

A pause. Then — recognition.

"Ah. The one who observed him."

Melissa wasn't surprised.

"He told you?"

"No. I saw it myself." Sati smiled slightly. "You looked at him the way a scientist looks at something rare. It was noticeable."

PHARMACY · OCTOBER · 16:22 SATI · ARTHUR'S ACQUAINTANCE · FIRST CONTACT
OBSERVATION: SEES THROUGH THE SITUATION SPEAKS DIRECTLY · WITHOUT SOFTENING TYPE:
THE SAME AS HIM · OR SIMILAR

They left the pharmacy together. Went to the café across the way.

"How is he now?" asked Sati.

"Well." A pause. "He's become different."

"I know. I saw him a month ago. Passed him at an intersection. He didn't recognize me."

"No. He recognized you. But — didn't see you."

Sati looked at her.

"You understand the difference," she said.

"I watched it for seven years."

Sati nodded.

"He always knew it would happen," she said quietly. "That someday he'd get tired. I told him then, the first time: you're not from here. Not to hurt him — because it was the truth, and the truth should be said. He laughed. Said: yes, I know. And in that laugh there was so much exhaustion..."

A pause.

"Do you transmit for him now?" asked Sati.

Melissa didn't answer at once.

"I'm trying," she said at last.

"That's right," Sati said simply. "The signal shouldn't be interrupted. Even if the carrier changes."

{ Sati knew. Not the way I knew — differently, with her own knowledge. She saw him at first sight seven years ago. I saw him for seven years — gradually, layer by layer. Different paths to one understanding. I wanted to ask her: are you not from here either? But I didn't. Some questions must be kept inside — until the right moment comes. }

They finished the coffee. Exchanged numbers.

"If you ever need to talk," said Sati. "Call."

Melissa walked home and thought: there are people who see through the surface. He was one of them. Sati — another. And she — a third. A student who inherited the instrument.

It was strange — and right at the same time.

Chapter 13. The Detective Finds the Date

In November she finished the reconstruction.

Three months of work with the archive. Three months — rereading, cross-referencing, building the timeline. And at last — an answer.

The point of no return: August. The stairwell. The first answer without the pause of translation.

But that wasn't the whole truth. That was the date of the symptom. The date of the cause was earlier.

She found it in the third week of November. She was leafing through the notebook from that summer — the very one — and stopped at an entry she hadn't singled out before.

{ July. He sat in the café with Alex. They didn't talk — just were near each other. Arthur looked out the window. Not through the Grid — I saw that. Just looked. Fifteen minutes. Alex didn't notice — he was on his phone. Arthur didn't notice I was observing. He was — just here. For the first time in three years of my watching him — just here, without the second layer. I wrote it down as an anomaly. I didn't know then that it was the beginning. }

July. The café. Alex. The first fifteen minutes without the Grid — voluntary, conscious, quiet.

Not the stairwell. The stairwell was the consequence. The cause — the café. The first taste of silence. The first "there it is — that's what he feels all the time." That was the beginning.

RECONSTRUCTION COMPLETE ————— DATE OF CAUSE: JULY
· CAFÉ — FIRST 15 MIN WITHOUT THE GRID · VOLUNTARILY — SUBJECT: DISCOVERED THE
SILENCE — SUBJECT: WANTED IT AGAIN ————— DATE OF
SYMPTOM: AUGUST · STAIRWELL — FIRST ANSWER WITHOUT THE PAUSE OF TRANSLATION — THE
ORGAN BEGAN TO ATROPHY ————— DATE OF NO RETURN:
AUTUMN · HARBOR — LAST ATTEMPT TO ACTIVATE THE GRID — FAILURE · ORGAN NON-
FUNCTIONAL ————— CONCLUSION: THE PROCESS TOOK ~4
MONTHS BEGINNING: DESIRE · END: IRREVERSIBILITY

She looked at the timeline.

Four months. July — November. From the first taste of silence to its full arrival.

It wasn't a betrayal of himself. It was exhaustion that found a way out. He wanted to rest. He rested — forever.

{ I don't blame him. I understand every step. I would probably have wanted it too — after seven years of translating myself every minute. I would have wanted to just be. The difference between us is that I — didn't translate. I observed. That's a different kind of effort. Less exhausting. Or — exhausting differently. }

She closed the notebook.

The investigation was over. The diagnosis made.

Now — what next.

Chapter 14. The Transmitter

December came with snow — the first, early, the kind that lies down and doesn't melt.

Melissa stood by the window and watched the flakes fall. In her head it was quiet — that particular quiet that comes after great work. Not emptiness. A saturated silence.

Three months of the archive. The point of no return found. The Grid grows — slowly, unevenly, but grows. Forty-three notebooks closed and put on the shelf. A new one — open.

She turned from the window and sat at the desk.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: WEAK · RISING RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
CARRIER: NEW

She wrote this and stopped at the last line.

Carrier: new.

It wasn't immodesty. It was a fact. The signal had found a new carrier — not because she wanted it, not because she decided. Because the organ had grown. Because seven years of observation had created in her something that now demanded an outlet.

She began to write.

About the December city beyond the window. About a man at the bus stop who looked at the snow the way one looks at something rare — with the surprise of a person who didn't expect beauty in this place. About a woman in a red coat who walked fast, but once stopped and lifted her face to the sky — a second, no more. About a teenager with headphones who picked up a stranger's dropped wallet and caught up with him — not because he had to, because he wanted to.

She wrote a long time.

BUS STOP · 17:58 SNOW · THE FIRST OF DECEMBER ARCHITECTURE OF THE MOMENT: — M · 60±5 · LOOKING AT THE SNOW · SURPRISE — F · RED COAT · ONE SECOND · THE SKY — TEENAGER · WALLET · CHOICE WITHOUT OBLIGATION COMMON: A MOMENT OF BEAUTY · UNPLANNED PEOPLE SLOW DOWN WHEN THE WORLD OFFERS BEAUTY THIS ISN'T WEAKNESS · IT'S — PRECISION OF PERCEPTION CONFIDENCE: 85%

She closed the notebook.

TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 23:17 SIGNAL: STEADY RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
STATUS: NORMAL

Outside, snow was falling. The city lived, breathed, moved.

Somewhere in another part of the city Arthur, probably, was also looking at the snow. Calm. One of the locals. Quiet.

Melissa poured tea. Set the cup beside the notebook.

She didn't know whether there was a recipient. She knew it didn't matter.

A signal seeks a recipient in the void. That's its nature. That's — the nature of any signal.

She took the cup. Sipped.

Warm.

{ I transmit. Not because I have to. Not because he transmitted. Because there's something to say — and there's an organ that knows how to formulate it. That's reason enough. That's — the only reason needed. }

The snow fell all night.

By morning the city was white — clean, untouched, like a page on which nothing has yet been written.

Melissa slept.

The signal did not break off.

The carrier changed — but the frequency remained.

That was all that was needed.

* * *

— END OF BOOK VIII —

— THE TRANSMITTER —

BOOK IX · FREQUENCY · FOLLOWS